Agency and Compliance at Work (#50372)

Author(s)
This pre-registration is currently anonymous to enable blind peer-review.
It has one author.

Pre-registered on:
2020/10/22 12:42 (PT)

1) Have any data been collected for this study already?
It's complicated. We have already collected some data but explain in Question 8 why readers may consider this a valid pre-registration nevertheless.

2) What's the main question being asked or hypothesis being tested in this study?
In Study 1, this research asks whether (in Western cultures), increasing employees' sense of themselves as moral agents, rather than as compliant with company values, will increase ethical decision-making (i.e., lead to less retaliatory customer sabotage). In Study 2, this research asks whether increasing employees' sense of themselves as moral agents, rather than as compliant with company values, will increase: ethical-decision-making, how secure and confident employees feel about their ethical decisions, and the extent to which they perceive the work environment as stressful. In Study 3, this research asks whether increasing employees' sense of themselves as moral agents, rather than as compliant with company values, will increase employees' creativity and innovation, and, again, investigates increases in ethical-decision-making, security, and confidence.

3) Describe the key dependent variable(s) specifying how they will be measured.
Our primary dependent variables will be three items measuring ethical decision-making about vignettes. After each vignette, participants will read the following question and select from the behaviors listed (Wang et al., 2011): "Based on SerVest's trust in you to make decisions [(Compliance condition) that reflect the rules of SerVest,] [(Agency Condition) by using your moral compass,] how likely is it that you would: Refuse to address the customer's issue, even though you could; Intentionally put the customer on hold for an unnecessarily long period of time; Purposefully transfer the customer to the wrong department; Purposefully disconnect the call; Tell the customer that you fixed the issue, even though you didn't fix it.
We create a total likelihood score.
Study 2 will include the same measures in Study 1. We will also measure how anxious respondents felt making the decisions, how confident they felt in responses, how comfortable they would be sharing their responses, and how stressful they think the workplace would be, using Likert-scale items. We will administer Rotter's Locus of Control scale at the end of the study. Study 3 include the same measures as Study 2. We will also measure creative output through the Creative Achievement Questionnaire (Carson, Peterson, & Higgins, 2005).

4) How many and which conditions will participants be assigned to?
Participants will be assigned to one of two between-subjects priming conditions (compliance, agency).

5) Specify exactly which analyses you will conduct to examine the main question/hypothesis.
The main hypothesis will be examined with analysis of variance to test the effect of the compliance/agency manipulation on overall sum of the likelihood responses for the unethical behaviors selected across the three vignettes. In Study 2, we will additionally use analyses of variance to test the effect of the compliance/agency manipulation on ratings of how anxious respondents felt making the decisions, how confident they felt in responses, how comfortable they would be sharing their responses, how stressful they think the workplace would be the creativity scale, and Rotter's LoC Scale scores. In Study 3, we will conduct the same analyses as the previous studies, with the addition of analysis of the effect of the manipulation on creativity scale scores.

6) Describe exactly how outliers will be defined and handled, and your precise rule(s) for excluding observations.
We will exclude participants who fail the attention checks embedded in the procedure, or the final item of the survey asking about attention. Failure of check 1 will entail two coders agreeing that the participant did not understand the policy. [Our measures include an open-ended manipulation check: respondent will be asked to "Please state the SerVest's Service Policy you just read in your own words." An independent coder will score the answers as to whether they indicate the respondent understood the policy as encouraging decision-making by following their moral compass or the company's rules.] Failure of check 2 will entail any responses other than the single response indicating the participant paid attention.

7) How many observations will be collected or what will determine sample size? No need to justify decision, but be precise about exactly how the number will be determined.
Per study: we aim for 240 participants, to allow for 100 per condition, and at least 40 exclusions due to inattention (failure of attention checks) or failing to complete the study.

8) Anything else you would like to pre-register? (e.g., secondary analyses, variables collected for exploratory purposes, unusual analyses planned?)
The data for Study 1 were collected online by the Business Simulation Lab at Cornell 2 days ago; I have not yet opened any data files, or looked at any data. This pre-registration was thought to be submitted, when it actually was not. Apologies for the confusion.